

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2001-04-04

To all National Spiritual Assemblies dear bahá'í

1 The international Teaching center has sought elucidation of issues con-
2 cerning the attitude of bahá'ís and bahá'í institutions towards those who
3 have withdrawn from the faith. in response, we have provided the following
4 comments, which are being sent to you for your information and guidance.
5 you are free to share this letter with the believers under your jurisdiction as
6 you wish.
7 one's beliefs are an internal and personal matter; no person or institution
8 has the right to exert compulsion in matters of belief. Since there is a wide range of
meanings in the Sacred Scriptures, there are bound to be differ-
9 ent ways in which individuals understand many of the bahá'í teachings.
10 Nevertheless, it is necessary for the viability of the bahá'í community that
11 its members share a common understanding of essentials. This implies a commitment
by each member to function within the framework established by such an understanding.
12 This framework includes, for example, cognizance of the existence of a
13 divine revelation brought by bahá'u'lláh, the manifestation of god for this 354.3
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356 2000–2001 • The Twentieth Plan
357 779age, and acceptance of the two primary duties prescribed by god, as ex-
358 pressed in the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the most holy book of the bahá'í revelation.

These are: “recognition of him who is the dayspring of his revelation

359 and the fountain of his laws,” and observance of “every ordinance of him
360 who is the desire of the world. These twin duties,” the Aqdas firmly states,

“are inseparable. Neither is acceptable without the other.”355-1

‘Abdu’l-b ahá, whom bahá’u’lláh appointed as the interpreter of his

361 writings, reaffirms these fundamentals of bahá’í belief. in his will and
362 Testament h e writes: “This is the foundation of the belief of the people of
363 bahá (may my life be offered up for them): ‘h is holiness, the exalted one
364 (the báb), is the manifestation of the unity and oneness of god and the
365 forerunner of the Ancient beauty. his holiness the Abhá beauty (may my
366 life be a sacrifice for his steadfast friends) is the Supreme manifestation of
367 god and the dayspring of his most divine essence. All others are servants

unto h im and do h is bidding.”355-2

368 it is within the context of these statements of basic belief and practice
369 that membership in the bahá’í faith is determined. Acknowledging that the
370 matter of ascertaining the qualification of a true believer is a delicate and
371 complex question, Shoghi effendi, the appointee of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá as guard-
372 ian of the cause and authorized interpreter of its teachings, set down for
373 Spiritual Assemblies the principal factors that must be taken into consider-
374 ation before deciding whether a person may be regarded as a true believer or
375 not: “f ull recognition of the station of the forerunner, the Author, and the
376 T rue exemplar of the bahá’í cause, as set forth in ‘Abdu’l-b ahá’s Testament;
377 unreserved acceptance of, and submission to, whatsoever has been revealed
378 by their pen; loyal and steadfast adherence to every clause of our beloved’s
379 sacred will; and close association with the spirit as well as the form of the

present day b ahá’í administration throughout the world. . . .”355-3

380 viewed in the light of these texts, a statement that one wishes to with-

draw from the bahá’í community, but not from the faith, is seen to be

381 self-contradictory. The bahá’í community must be seen in its proper light.

382 The necessity for its existence as an inseparable element of the faith itself

383 355-1. kA, ¶1.

384 355-2. w T, p. 19.

385 355-3. bA, p. 90.355.4

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356 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
357 780 is explained by the stated purpose of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh: to bring
358 about a divine civilization. The embodiment of that purpose and of the
359 spirit breathed by bahá'u'lláh into the world is the order he has ordained,
360 to which he refers in the most holy book in asserting: "The world's equilib-
361 rium hath been upset through the vibrating influence of this most great, this
362 new world order. mankind's ordered life hath been revolutionized through
363 the agency of this unique, this wondrous System—the like of which mortal eyes have
never witnessed."

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365 Normally, a Spiritual Assembly is called upon to make a decision in such
366 matters only as the result of an action by an individual, either in declaring
367 his belief in bahá'u'lláh, or in stating that he wishes to withdraw from the
368 faith, or, very rarely, in persistently promoting concepts which are clearly
369 inconsistent with the essentials of membership outlined above.
370 Acceptance of the faith is the voluntary act of an individual and is reg-
371 istered by the appropriate bahá'í institution unless it has good reason not
372 to do so. likewise, a bahá'í is free to leave the faith voluntarily. when a
373 member of the community informs the Assembly of his wish to withdraw,
374 it would try to help him overcome whatever problems seem to be the cause
375 of his desiring to take such a step. if he persists in his intention, the As-
376 sembly would normally accept the withdrawal unless there were grounds for
377 suspecting that he is acting insincerely out of some ulterior motive, such as
378 to violate a bahá'í law with impunity.

in spite of loving encouragement given by their Assemblies, not all

379 bahá'ís are active in the work of the community. This does not, of course,
380 necessarily indicate withdrawal. An Assembly should carefully distinguish between
those who are not active but still identify themselves with the faith,
381 and those whose inactivity indicates complete lack of interest and a wish to
382 have nothing more to do with the cause.
383 once a person's resignation from the faith has been accepted, his status

384 is that of a non-bahá'í and—except as noted below—his relationship with
385 bahá'í institutions and individual believers is the same as that of any other
386 non-bahá'í. As in all human relationships, the closeness of this connection,
387 and the warmth of friendship, depend upon personal factors.
388 Sometimes, after a person's withdrawal from the cause has been accept-
389 ed, it becomes evident that his statements were insincere and were made
390 355-4. gwb, no. 70.1.355.7
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356 2000–2001 • The Twelve on the Plan
357 781merely in order to evade bahá'í law. The Assembly need not take any overt
358 action in such a case, but would note the matter in its records. in other
359 words, it would have to be cautious about accepting a subsequent declara-
360 tion of belief from this individual until satisfied that it is made in good faith. Also,
depending upon the circumstances, the Assembly might require him to rectify the action,
taken in violation of bahá'í law, which was the
361 motive for his withdrawing from the faith.

An analogous situation arises when a person who is engaged in some

362 activity which he suspects would result in his being declared a covenant-
363 breaker withdraws from the faith under the impression that this step would
364 the withdrawal provides adequate protection of the community from the individual
in question. however, if he persists, following his withdrawal, in
365 trying to undermine the covenant or joins forces with covenant-breakers,
366 he may be judged to have broken the covenant, and the friends would be
367 told to have no association with him. each such case would be considered
368 in the context of its specific circumstances.
369 There is one other condition which should be mentioned. There are cer-
370 tain former bahá'ís whose actions do not necessarily constitute covenant-
371 breaking, but are seriously destructive. where such people have shown that
372 they are impervious to explanations or exhortations from the bahá'í institu-

373 tions, continued association with them can be burdensome and can exert a spiritually
corrosive effect on the faith of believers. in such cases the head of

374 the faith may simply advise the bahá'ís to leave them to their own devices.

375 Thus, there are exceptional cases in which a former believer's spiritual at-

376 titude to the faith may, to various degrees, create an estrangement between

377 him and the bahá'ís. in general, however, a person who has withdrawn from

the faith is regarded as being among the generality of humankind with

whom the bahá'ís are enjoined to associate "in joy and fragrance."

378 with loving bahá'í greetings,

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The Lesser Peace

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]